

GitHub Copilot for VS Code: Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

Essential Keyboard Shortcuts (Windows)

Code Suggestions

Action	Shortcut	Description
Accept Suggestion	Tab	Accept the current Copilot suggestion
Reject Suggestion	Esc	Dismiss the current suggestion
Next Suggestion	Alt +]	Cycle to the next alternative suggestion
Previous Suggestion	Alt + [	Cycle to the previous alternative suggestion
Trigger Suggestion	Ctrl + Space	Manually trigger Copilot suggestions
Accept Word	Ctrl + →	Accept only the next word of the suggestion
Accept Line	Ctrl + Enter	Accept only the current line of the suggestion

Copilot Chat

Action	Shortcut	Description
Open Chat View	Ctrl + Alt + I	Open Copilot Chat panel in sidebar
Inline Chat	Ctrl + I	Open inline chat in editor
Voice Chat	Ctrl + I (hold)	Start voice conversation with Copilot
New Chat Session	Ctrl + N	Start new chat session in Chat view
Agent Mode	Ctrl + Shift + I	Switch to agent mode

Reference: [GitHub Copilot in VS Code Features](#)

Copilot Chat Commands & Variables

Chat Variables (Use # to reference context)

Variable	Description	Example
#file	Include current file's content	#file explain this function
#selection	Include currently selected text	#selection optimize this code
#function	Include current function/method	#function add error handling
#class	Include current class	#class explain this design pattern
#line	Include current line of code	#line fix this syntax error

Variable	Description	Example
#project	Include project context	#project show me all API routes
#sym	Include current symbol	#sym explain this variable
#block	Include current block of code	#block what does this do?
#path	Include file path	#path where is this file located?
#comment	Include current comment	#comment explain this TODO

Slash Commands (Official VS Code commands)

Command	Description	Example
/clear	Start a new chat session	/clear
/explain	Explain how code works	/explain how does this algorithm work?
/fix	Propose fixes for problems	/fix this function has a bug
/tests	Generate unit tests	/tests create tests for this function
/new	Create a new project	/new create a React app
/help	Quick reference for Copilot	/help
/fixTestFailure	Find and fix failing tests	/fixTestFailure why is this test breaking?

Reference: [GitHub Copilot Chat Cheat Sheet](#)

Chat Participants & Agents

Chat Participants (Official agents)

Agent	Command	Description
Workspace	@workspace	Ask questions about your codebase structure and patterns
VSCode	@vscode	Get help with VS Code features and settings
Terminal	@terminal	Get help with terminal/command line tasks
GitHub	@github	Access GitHub-specific skills and repository information

Chat Participant Examples

@workspace how do I add authentication to this app?

@workspace find all TODO comments in my project

@vscode how do I set up debugging for Node.js?

@terminal how do I create a git branch?

@github what issues are assigned to me?

Reference: [Using GitHub Copilot Chat Participants](#)

Status Bar Indicators

Copilot Status Icons

Icon	Meaning
 Active	Copilot is active and ready
 Paused	Suggestions are paused
 Disabled	Copilot is disabled for this file type
 Warning	Authentication or connection issue

Reference: [Configuring GitHub Copilot in VS Code](#)

Chat Modes

Available Chat Modes

Mode	Description	Best For
Ask	Get answers and code suggestions	Questions about code, explanations, general help
Edit	Make changes across multiple files	Coordinated edits, refactoring across project
Agent	Autonomous multi-step workflows	Complex tasks, feature implementation

How to Switch Modes

- Use the dropdown at the top of the Chat view
- Or use `Ctrl + Shift + I` to switch to Agent mode directly

Reference: [Using Chat in VS Code](#)

Prompt Files & Customization

Copilot Instructions File

File: `.github/copilot-instructions.md` **Purpose:** Global instructions that apply to all Copilot interactions in

your project **Usage:** Automatically included in every chat request

markdown

Project: E-commerce Platform

Use TypeScript for all new code.

Follow our coding standards: camelCase, descriptive names.

Include error handling and JSDoc comments.

Prefer async/await over promises.

Custom Prompt Files

Location: `.github/prompts/` **Extension:** `.prompt.md` **Purpose:** Reusable prompts for common tasks

Usage: Reference with `#prompt:filename`

Example: Code Review Prompt

File: `.github/prompts/code-review.prompt.md`

markdown

Review this code for:

- Security vulnerabilities
- Performance issues
- Code style consistency
- Best practices adherence
- Documentation completeness

Example: API Development Prompt

File: `.github/prompts/api-development.prompt.md`

markdown

Create a REST API endpoint that:

- Follows RESTful conventions
- Includes proper error handling
- Has input validation
- Returns appropriate HTTP status codes
- Includes OpenAPI documentation

Chat Mode Files

Location: `.github/copilot-chat-modes/` **Extension:** `.md` **Purpose:** Define specialized chat behaviors and

tool access **Usage:** Select from chat mode dropdown

Example: Code Reviewer Mode

File: `.github/copilot-chat-modes/code-reviewer.md`

```
markdown
---
description: 'Review code for quality and adherence to best practices.'
tools: ['codebase', 'usages', 'vscodeAPI', 'problems']
---
# Code Reviewer Mode
You are a senior developer conducting thorough code reviews.
Focus on code quality, security, and maintainability.
```

Language-Specific Instructions

Purpose: Provide language-specific guidance for better code generation **Usage:** Automatically applied when working in specific languages

Example: JavaScript Instructions

```
markdown
# JavaScript Guidelines
- Use ES6+ features (arrow functions, destructuring, modules)
- Prefer const/let over var
- Use template literals for string interpolation
- Include proper error handling with try/catch
```

How to Use Prompt Files

Action	Command	Example
Reference Prompt File	<code>#prompt:filename</code>	<code>#prompt:code-review check this function</code>
Add Context	Click  in chat input	Select prompt file from context menu
Create New Prompt	Save <code>.prompt.md</code> in <code>.github/prompts/</code>	Custom prompts appear in <code>#prompt:</code> suggestions

Reference: [Customize Chat Responses in VS Code](#)

Remember

- **Copilot is a tool, you're the developer** - Always review and understand generated code
- **Context is key** - The more context you provide, the better the suggestions
- **Experiment freely** - Try different prompting styles to see what works best
- **Stay curious** - Use Copilot to explore new patterns and approaches